



Elite experience: India coach Amelia Valverde (far right) comes with notable pedigree. In her previous assignment, she guided Costa Rica (in red) to two FIFA World Cups, including the most recent edition in 2023 (above). AFP

PLAYERS TO WATCH OUT FOR

- HINATA MIYAZAWA**
POSITION: FORWARD
GOALS: 9
CLUB: MANCHESTER UNITED
- SAM KERR**
POSITION: STRIKER
GOALS: 69
CLUB: CHELSEA
- JI SO-YUN**
POSITION: MIDFIELDER
GOALS: 74
CLUB: SUWON FC
- WANG SHUANG**
POSITION: WINGER
GOALS: 47
CLUB: WUHAN JIANGDA
- HUYNH NHI**
POSITION: FORWARD
GOALS: 70
CLUB: HO CHI MINH CITY I

Cups. She has previously faced four Asian opponents as coach — Japan, South Korea, China and the Philippines — losing only to Japan, the 2011 World Cup winner and the highest-ranked team going into the tournament.

“In our group (for this edition), we have different (types of) opponents. Japan is a favourite, whatever the tournament. It is like a clock — very disciplined. They do everything in a calculated fashion and are always looking to go forward,” Valverde says.

“Vietnam and Chinese Taipei are both well organised but in a developmental stage. Chinese Taipei is particularly fast.”

With India, Valverde will find solace in the quality of the squad she has inherited, for it has multiple players with overseas experience. For instance, Aveka Singh plays for Danish second division side Næstved HG, while Manisha Kalyan plies her trade with Peruvian top-flight side

Alianza Lima.

The duo, along with Soumya Guguloth — she previously won the Croatian Premier Division with Dinamo Zagreb — and Dangmei Grace — who previously won the Uzbekistan top-flight title with Sevinch Karshi — will form a promising head of the Valverde’s preferred 3-4-3 diamond formation.

Sangita Basfore (**right**), whose heroics propelled India into the tournament — she scored both goals against Thailand — will be the lynchpin in midfield. East Bengal’s Indian Women’s League-winning captain Sweetie Devi is expected to marshal the defence.

Under Crispin Chhetri and Thomas Dennerby, India played with a four-member backline, which is likely to morph into a back three with a narrow front line, à la Antonio Conte — one that Valverde employed for Costa Rica.

The coach, however, has kept her cards close to her chest in this stint,